

In the end, it was an exercise in rhetoric when the much-hyped nuclear debate finally took place in the Lok Sabha. The Congress—as expected—was attacked by both the Left and the Right with BJP hardening its stance on the deal. In fact, Leader of the Opposition L.K. Advani categorically stated that if the BJP-led NDA came to power “we would renegotiate the deal and if that would not be possible we do not even mind cancelling it”. This effectively dashed any hopes the Congress might have harboured of winning BJP over to its side. The fortnight before the deal had seen some hectic lobbying from the Government’s side with the prime minister himself calling on former prime minister A.B. Vajpayee. But Advani’s strong statements in the House closed any window of an opportunistic alliance with the saffron party. BJP’s future prime ministerial candidate minced no words in rejecting the nuclear deal in its current form.

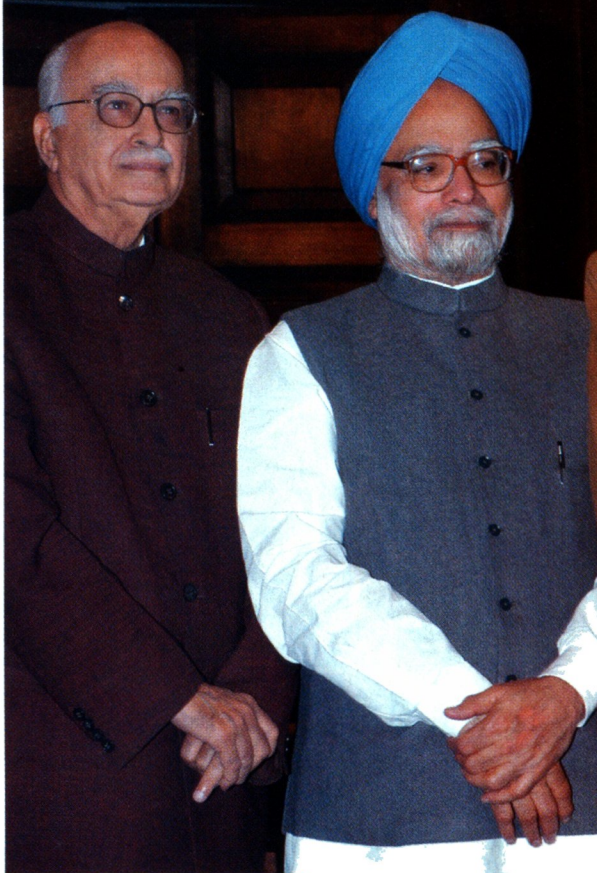
The Left, while sticking to the expected script in opposing the deal was less strident in its opposition. The high-pitched rhetoric that had so far characterised the Marxists’ opposition was missing. Regardless, there was no room for doubt: the sense of the House was categorically against the deal. On the eve of the debate the Congress tried to paint it as a mere academic exercise with Parliamentary Affairs Minister Priya Ranjan Dasmunsi refusing to admit that the debate would give the sense of the House. Both the BJP and the Left had been trying to corner the Government on this issue by claiming that the prime minister was trying to push through a deal that a majority of Parliament was against. “If Advani opposes the deal, he does so with the backing of 129 BJP MPs, and the same goes for the Left and so on. How can the Congress claim that this is not the sense of the House?” said V.K. Malhotra.

Interestingly, apart from External

Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee, the Congress did not field any of its stalwarts for the debate, leaving it to the young MPs’ brigade to defend the trophy deal of the UPA Government. When the prime minister himself did not rise to reply and fielded Mukherjee, BJP staged a walkout. However, Manmohan had intervened earlier, reacting to one of Advani’s more pointed barbs when he alleged that “the deal takes away India’s right to test and treats New Delhi as the junior partner”. Clearly in his element, Advani

COLD FUSION

A restrained Left and a defensive UPA take the heat of the nuclear debate even as the BJP raises the stakes



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LEADER OF THE OPPOSITION

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MANMOHAN SINGH
PRIME MINISTER

said while Indira Gandhi had conducted Pokhran I and Vajpayee had conducted Pokhran II, Manmohan had ensured that there would be no Pokhran III. At this point the prime minister said, “If a necessity for carrying out a nuclear test arises in future, there is nothing in the agreement that prevents us from carrying out tests.”

The UPA allies spoke in favour of the deal. However, while pointing out that it would help India meet its energy needs, D.P. Yadav cautioned that if some of the allies did not support the deal then some alternative methods could be explored. BSP played hardball and wanted an all-party meeting to explain some of its reservations on the deal. The Samajwadi Party surprisingly, came out in support of the deal. However, most of the thunder had already taken place outside Parliament during the UPA-Left Co-ordination Committee meet. Having got the Left’s go-ahead to initiate talks with the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) the Government was sanguine in its approach. Any fire there was came from BJP. In fact, things were almost back to normal with more sparring between the Congress and the BJP than between the treasury benches and the Left. When Advani insisted on the prime minister’s reply, Dasmunsi shot back and reminded him that while

Manmohan had spoken on this four times, BJP was yet to inform the House of its talks with Strobe Talbott.

However, if the usual fiery Left leaders were restrained with their emotions in the House, they seemed confident in their willingness to veto the bilateral treaty. As it is the Government would have to return to the UPA-Left Coordination Committee on the agreement after speaking with IAEA on India-specific safeguards. And that clearly is the real battleground.

by Priya Sahgal